

form of a 90-minute, five-movement “symphonic poem” for two soloists, male chorus, and orchestra.

In 1888, Sibelius had met Aino Järnefelt, the 17-year-old daughter of an aristocratic family who, unusually for their class, were Finnish-speaking nationalists. The couple were married soon after *Kullervo*’s premiere, and the first of their six daughters (one died in infancy) was born the following year.



SCENE FROM THE *KALEVALA*

A 19th-century watercolor depicts the character in the Finnish epic the *Kalevala* on whom Sibelius based his symphonic poem, *Kullervo*. The music’s surging symphonic command and ultra-vivid evocation of the Finnish landscape were instantly acclaimed.

New directions

Sibelius now grappled with the issues of how to earn a living (part-time teaching at the Music Institute helped) and what to compose next. His first response was the symphonic poem *En*